

Pikachu's orbital adventure brings space science to Pokémon fans

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A Pikachu plush has completed a space adventure with real spacecraft and a real destination. The European Space Agency, or ESA, revealed on September 19, 2026, that the toy had spent 67 days aboard the International Space Station.

The plush travelled to the station on April 11 aboard a Cygnus **cargo** spacecraft and returned to Earth on June 17 in a SpaceX Dragon **cargo** spacecraft. These vehicles carry **cargo**, meaning supplies and other items. During its stay in **orbit**, the toy completed about 1,040 journeys around Earth. **Orbit** describes the curved path followed by an object travelling around a planet or another body in space.

The project is linked to World Space Week 2026, scheduled for October 4 through 10. ESA has created an **exhibition** that combines Pokémon characters with space science. Displays introduce European space missions and life aboard the station. Visitors can also explore how ESA studies the Sun, the Solar System and the wider universe.

The **exhibition** tour began at ESA headquarters in Paris in late September. It is planned to visit museums and other **venues** across Europe through April 2027.

Pokémon GO players can take part at participating European science and space museums from October 4, 2026, through April 30, 2027. Activities include One-Star **Raids** featuring Astronaut Pikachu, research tasks and chances to encounter event-themed Pokémon. **Raids** are a type of challenge within the game.

ESA hopes that connecting familiar characters with real missions will spark **curiosity** about space and science among children and teenagers.

Word Treasure

cargo -- Supplies and other items transported by a vehicle.

orbit -- The curved path an object follows around another body in space.

exhibition -- A collection of displays that visitors can explore.

venues -- Places where events or activities take place.

Raids -- A type of challenge in Pokémon GO.

curiosity -- A desire to learn or understand something.

Background you need

Cargo spacecraft carry supplies and other items.

An orbit is a curved path around a planet or another body in space.

Raids are a type of challenge within Pokémon GO.

Break it down

Opens with ESA's announcement and the length of the toy's visit.

Explains the spacecraft journeys, cargo and orbit.

Introduces World Space Week and the exhibition's science topics.

Gives the exhibition tour location and schedule.

Describes museum game activities and ESA's educational aim.

Why it matters

The exhibition introduces real space missions and research through familiar Pokémon characters. It offers a starting point for learning about the space station, the Solar System and the universe.

Test what you remember

1. When did ESA reveal the Pikachu plush's space-station visit?
 - (A) September 19, 2026
 - (B) October 29, 2026
 - (C) October 19, 2026
 - (D) September 29, 2026
2. Which pair correctly matches the toy's outward and return spacecraft?
 - (A) Dragon outward, Dragon back
 - (B) Cygnus outward, Dragon back
 - (C) Dragon outward, Cygnus back
 - (D) Cygnus outward, Cygnus back
3. What does an orbit describe?
 - (A) The curved path around a space body
 - (B) The displays arranged inside a museum
 - (C) The supplies carried inside a spacecraft
 - (D) The tasks completed inside a game
4. Which subjects can visitors explore in the exhibition?
 - (A) The towns, cities and villages
 - (B) The forests, deserts and grasslands
 - (C) The oceans, rivers and lakes
 - (D) The Sun, Solar System and universe
5. Through which month will the exhibition tour travel across Europe?
 - (A) April 2027
 - (B) February 2027
 - (C) March 2027
 - (D) May 2027
6. Where can players join the special Pokémon GO activities?
 - (A) Participating European music and theatre venues
 - (B) Participating European wildlife and nature parks
 - (C) Participating European science and space museums
 - (D) Participating European sports and leisure centres

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: B 3: A 4: D 5: A 6: C

Questions to think about

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):